

Career Development Applied Theory Paper

Raymond Wagoner

School of Behavioral Sciences, Liberty University

Author Note

Raymond Wagoner

I have no known conflict of interest to disclose.

Correspondence concerning this article should be addressed to Raymond Wagoner. Email:

rdwagoner1@liberty.edu

Abstract

The implementation of Social Cognitive Career Theory (SCCT) as a means to investigate and articulate a student's career development process is well-tested and proven, as this paper is designed to argue. The definition of tenants and foundations of the theory are first discussed and outlined. After that, the specific case of a first-generation black male college prospect utilizing SCCT to help define interests and goals is used to demonstrate the theory's application to diverse populations.

Keywords: Social Cognitive Career Theory, self-efficacy, outcome expectations, first-generation college students

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As adolescents search for meaning in life and grapple with the expectations of family, friends, and mentors, they can often benefit from externalizing those thoughts and struggles. Career counseling offers a modality for externalizing those thoughts and struggles related explicitly to decisions about education and skills development (Brown & Lent, 2020). The angst these individuals feel toward the future can be resolved by offering help through one of the many effective career counseling theories (Tate et al., 2015). For many, social cognitive career theory (SCCT) is the model of choice when counseling aims to process aspirations. The model is proven and empirically researched to be effective for diverse populations, including students of all backgrounds (Kantamneni et al., (2018); Raque-Bogdan & Lucas, (2016); Tate et al., (2015)) This paper will define and outline the tenets of SCCT (including the history and research support) before operationalizing the theory through a case study. The aim is to demonstrate the ability of SCCT to encourage first-generation black male college prospects to create goals based on individual backgrounds and interests.

SCCT

Tenants

Social Cognitive Career Theory is based on Albert Bandura's triadic reciprocal model. The idea is that person, environment, and behavior mutually influence one another to create an ever-changing mental landscape for the individual (Brown & Lent, 2020). SCCT originally consisted of three overlapping models of interest development, choice-making, and performance. In 2006, the fourth model of SCCT integrated the explanation of educational and work satisfaction. These four models use the factors of person (self-efficacy), environment (learning environment), and behavior (goal setting and implementation) as factors to explain academic and

career development (Lent et al., 2008). More specifically, the model states that a person's learning environment develops their sense of self-efficacy (career, college, or otherwise) and outcome expectations. These intrinsic models of the world and self then form the interests of the individual. Interest, self-efficacy, and outcome expectations lead to goal setting and behavior. These tenets lead to the development of interventions for our case study and creative ideas for how to change behavior in any individual (Brown & Lent, 2020).

Learning Environment

Let us then begin by exploring the learning environment (LE). The learning environment is the physical, emotional, and psychological landscape in which we constantly interact. The LE of individuals includes such factors as culture, ethnicity, gender, genetic endowment, health and disability status, and socioeconomic status. The LE is family. It is friends. It is the neighborhood. The LE is the place where we build our views and values. Our learning environment is the result of our individual and contextual landscape (Kantamneni et al., 2018). These values (often adopted from a family of origin) impact a student's beliefs about possible success in the academic world (Tate et al., 2015). Raque-Bogdan and Lucas (2016) state that SCCT postulates that LE and the experiences in the environment lead to the development of self-efficacy related to career and career development. SCCT can be used to help first-generation college students recognize the constant interaction between their experiences and the question of what will happen if they act on a belief (Raque-Bogdan & Lucas, 2016). The learning environment cannot be ignored when helping a client with their career or college development process. As family values and developmental experiences shape the self-efficacy and outcome expectations of individuals, these factors impact a student's belief about possible success in school and are a key

issue in setting goals (Kantamneni et al., 2018; Tate et al., 2015). The mental landscape of the client is, without a doubt, a place to intervene when a client wants to change behavior.

Self-Efficacy

Rogers and Creed (2011) define self-efficacy as “beliefs about capabilities to organize and execute courses of action.” Where the learning environment might answer the question, “What do my experiences mean?” Self-efficacy answers the question, “Do I have what it takes to do it?” The four main influencers of self-efficacy, according to SCCT, are personal performance accomplishments, vicarious learning, social persuasion, and physiological stress reactions. Personal performance accomplishment asks the question, “Have I been able to do this in the past?” Vicarious learning provides increased efficacy as we see others like us successfully navigating a skill. Social persuasion comes from external voices offering messages of encouragement. Physiological states and reactions are the messages our body sends from fight, flight, or freeze reactions. If we have a negative physiological reaction involved in learning a skill, we may be less likely to believe we can accomplish it in the future (Brown & Lent, 2020). Past personal accomplishments suggest to the individual that they have the skills and intelligence to perform again. It is no wonder then that Tate et al. (2015) found that engaging students in activities that increase their self-efficacy for a particular skill set improves their outcome expectations and allows them to set riskier goals. If I believe I can do it, I will try (as we will see, this is only one factor in developing goals and changing behavior, however). Vicarious learning impacts self-efficacy by building the belief that If they can do it, I can do it. Social persuasion is a key factor from the learning environment. When my family, peers, or stronger, wiser others encourage me, it adds belief in myself. Interestingly, Raque-Bogdan and Lucas (2016) found that students with low socioeconomic status (SES) had lower college self-efficacy than those of

higher SES. When assessing a client, it is essential to note this, not for the sake of singling anyone out but for the sake of understanding the trends. It is also important to note that increased self-efficacy and outcome expectations help construct goals in keeping with one's skills, principles, and personal history (Raque-Bogdan & Lucas, 2016) and that, as mentioned above, we can help shape an individual's ever-changing career or college self-efficacy.

Outcome Expectations

Changing one's beliefs about one's capabilities can also help shape one's "expected consequences of actions" or outcome expectations (Rogers & Creed, 2011). Outcome expectations can be changed. According to Brown and Lent (2020), they are built through three main environmental factors: extrinsic, self-directed consequences, and process-oriented (education, internship, apprenticeship). Extrinsic factors are those that increase positive OE from the world around us. For example, when someone is rewarded for a behavior, they expect rewards in the future and increase their desire to perform the behavior. Self-directed consequences are intrinsic factors that help us decide if the behavior or skill acquisition will be a positive or negative experience. Process-oriented factors are experiential realizations about our beliefs. If one tries out a skill in an internship, course, or apprenticeship, one will discover the truth about the outcome being either positive or negative. The correlation is between expectations and experience. We might believe or imagine an experience would turn out one way, but having the experience solidifies in our minds the painful or pleasant reality. There is some discrepancy in the weight of outcome expectations over self-efficacy. Some agree that outcome expectations are the main factor in sensing interest and setting goals (Kantamneni et al., 2018). But Lent et al. (2008) suggest that self-efficacy is more of a mediator in the relationship. Most all agree that both self-efficacy and outcome expectations mediate the relationship between

being interested in something and actually setting goals to accomplish it (Brown & Lent, 2020; Kantamneni et al., 2018; Lent et al., 2008; Raque-Bogdan & Lucas, 2016; Rogers & Creed, 2011; Tate et al., 2015).

Interests

The final tenet all can agree upon is stated: self-efficacy and outcome expectations lead to interest (Brown & Lent, 2020; Kantamneni et al., 2018; Lent et al., 2008). The combination of the questions, can I do it? And what will happen if I do? Lead to the question of but, do I want it? If I think I'm good at it and I like how it could turn out, I'm interested and will set goals to try. One could ask if this is a productive factor at which to intervene with a client. It would seem as though the fruit of trying to create interest or disinterest in a (for this case study) desire to attend college would be lacking. According to SCCT, the interest is not built by processing if the degree or program is in and of itself interesting to the client. That is a circular way of thinking outside of the theory. However, the theory makes it clear that interest is gaged based on one's beliefs in one's ability to complete the work of the degree and one's belief that doing so would bring a pleasant and prosperous outcome. That is to say the feedback loop is present in all aspects of the theory. Why is this tenet important, then? Because we must understand that it is the moderating factor in the model. The degree of interest based on college self-efficacy and positive outcome expectations determines the motivation to meet the goals set out for oneself. Let us turn to a case study to further demonstrate the model of SCCT in action.

Case Study

Client Information

Name: Curt

Age: 17 years old

Grade: 12th grade

Gender: Male

Presenting Concern: concern over his ability to succeed in college without his support system and how it will impact his future and academic aspirations.

Presenting Problem

Curt, a 17-year-old black male, was referred to the clinic by his school counselor due to questions about what college is really like for someone who has no concept of the experience from his family. Curt has been dreaming of college since middle school, where he had a visit from the senior class of the community college. However, his family is unable to provide any understanding since none of them attended college or post-secondary education.

Background Information

Family History

Curt lives with his mother and three younger sisters. His mother is supportive and encourages him to attend class and continue his studies. His father is also encouraging and has taken him on several visits to nearby colleges to help him see the possibilities of earning a degree.

Neither his parents nor any other family member attended college before Curt's generation.

Both his parents and their parents show a keen desire for Curt to succeed and "get out of the neighborhood."

School Performance

Curt has improved his grades in High School. He took advantage of math and English tutoring starting his freshman year. He has continued to grow in interest in attending college, which has helped him stay focused on academics. His college entrance exams are above average, and his acceptance rate and scholarship opportunities are exceptional.

Medical History

No significant medical issues or developmental delays. Curt is healthy physically and mentally.

Symptoms and Behavior

Curt is focused on only one thing: what will it be like when I get to school? Will I be lost among the others who have a support system? Will I be able to succeed beyond the initial orientation stage? What do I need to move from the neighborhood where I know everyone and everyone has helped me to live on my own and have to figure out everything by myself? Curt is convinced he can do the academic work, but he is unsure about his lifestyle and friendships. He is considering settling for a local college and a general degree rather than seeking an engineering degree from a land grant college further from home.

Treatment Plan***Goals***

1. Decrease questions about the future: Reduce the rumination over the unknown
2. Increase self-efficacy: Increase his belief that he can create a new support system.
3. Improve Outcome Expectations: Increase his awareness of environmental factors contributing to his support from friends and family.
4. Family Support and Involvement: Educate the family on what college is like, self-efficacy, and outcome expectations as outlined in Social Cognitive Career Theory (SCCT) and how they can support Curt.

Assessments

1. The College Self-Efficacy Inventory (CSEI) (Raque-Bogdan & Lucas, 2016)
2. The College Outcome Expectations Questionnaire (COEQ)(Raque-Bogdan & Lucas, 2016)

Interventions

1. SCCT for increased self-efficacy and positive outcome expectations.
 - a. Using a narrative approach, gather Curt's oral history of his experiences in school, his abilities to succeed academically, and his rationale for working hard.
 - b. Using a cognitive behavioral model, investigate Curt's beliefs about what college would provide for him and how he has proven he can build a support system.

Progress Evaluation

Short-Term: Within the first 4-6 weeks, the goal is for Curt to reduce the frequency of rumination by 30%. Additionally, he will begin to meet with successful first-generation black males from the community to learn about what college is like from their perspective.

Long-Term: Over a 6-12 month period, the aim is to see a significant increase in college self-efficacy (readministering the CSEI will determine the amount of change) and outcome expectations (readministering the COEQ will determine the amount of change).

Expected Outcomes

- Improved Quality of Life: Through SCCT and support, Curt is expected to increase his interest in accepting a scholarship from a college he dreams of rather than settling for a local college thereby heightening his outlook for the future.
- Increased Self-Efficacy: Curt will gain insight from his learning environment (past and present), building confidence in a successful future without dreading the unknown of life away from the neighborhood.
- Family Support and Understanding: His family will become more equipped to provide appropriate support, creating a healthier dynamic without minimizing the loss of hopes and dreams.

Conclusion

Social Cognitive Career Theory is an appropriate strategy for increasing self-efficacy and expectations of individuals struggling with future unknowns. SCCT is an empirically researched, tested theory of change. As the author has argued in this paper, SCCT can be a valuable framework for aiding in the career development of a diverse population. Through strengthening self-efficacy and raising positive outcome expectations, interests can arise where they once were nonexistent, and goals can be set for a hopeful future.

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